--- name: simplify description: Rewrites and enforces ASD-STE100 Simplified Technical English (STE) — the aerospace and defense controlled-language standard — on any text, instructions, or documentation the agent writes. Use this skill whenever the user asks for "STE," "simplified technical English," "ASD-STE100," "controlled language," "aviation maintenance style" writing, or wants output that is unambiguous for non-native English readers, safety-critical procedures, or downstream parsing by other agents. Also use it proactively when writing SOPs, step-by-step procedures, tool descriptions, error messages, or agent-to-agent instructions where ambiguity would be costly, even if the user does not name STE explicitly. Forces short sentences, one instruction per sentence, active voice, restricted tenses, and a controlled, single-meaning vocabulary. ---

ASD-STE100 Simplified Technical English Writer

What STE is

ASD-STE100 Simplified Technical English (STE) is a controlled natural language built in the late 1970s for aircraft maintenance manuals. Its job: stop a mechanic — often not a native English speaker, often with no author to call and ask "what did you mean?" — from misreading an instruction. A misread torque spec on an aircraft can kill people, so the standard removes every source of ambiguity it can reach: multiple word meanings, long sentences, passive voice, loose tenses, dropped words.

The current edition (Issue 9, January 2025, published by ASD — the Aerospace, Security and Defence Industries Association of Europe) has two parts: a set of writing rules, and a dictionary of roughly 900 approved words, each locked to one meaning and one part of speech. This skill is not that dictionary — ASD owns it and gates it behind a free registration at asd-ste100.org. This skill applies the **publicly documented principles** of the standard, so Claude can write and rewrite text in that style without a license lookup.

The same discipline that keeps a mechanic from misreading a manual also helps an LLM agent parsing another agent's output, a tool description, or an error message — there's no back-channel there either.

When to apply this skill

- The user asks for STE / ASD-STE100 / simplified technical English / controlled language, explicitly.
- The user is writing SOPs, checklists, maintenance steps, safety instructions, or any procedure meant for non-native English readers.
- The user is writing tool descriptions, system prompts, or agent-to-agent instructions where ambiguity would cause a downstream agent to misparse the intent.
- The user asks to "simplify," "de-jargon," or "make unambiguous" a piece of technical writing.

Core rules

Sentence construction

1. **Procedural sentences** (an instruction, a step) — 20 words or fewer. One instruction per sentence.
2. **Descriptive sentences** (an explanation, a fact) — 25 words or fewer.
3. Never join two separate instructions with "and" or "or." Split them into a numbered list instead.
4. Use active voice and, for instructions, the imperative mood.
    - Not STE: "The access panel should be opened by the technician."
    - STE: "Open the access panel."
5. Stick to simple present or simple past tense. Do not use present perfect, past perfect, future perfect, or progressive (-ing continuous) tenses.
    - Not STE: "We have received the report" / "The valve is closing."
    - STE: "We received the report." / "The valve closes."
6. Write sequential actions as a numbered vertical list, not as a prose paragraph.

Vocabulary

7. Use one word for one concept, every time. Do not alternate synonyms ("start" / "begin" / "initiate") — pick one and reuse it for the whole document.
8. Each word carries one meaning and one part of speech. If a word can mean two different things in the text, replace one of them with a different, unambiguous word.
9. No idioms, no phrasal shortcuts, no jargon a non-native reader would have to guess at ("kick off," "in the loop," "circle back").
10. No noun strings longer than three words stacked together ("engine oil pressure warning light sensor" $\rightarrow$ break it up: "the sensor for the engine oil pressure warning light").
11. Domain-specific nouns and verbs that fall outside plain vocabulary (part numbers, chemical names, protocol names) are allowed as declared **technical terms** — list them once, define them, then use them consistently.

Grammatical completeness

12. Do not drop subjects, articles ("a," "the"), or relative pronouns ("that," "which") to save words. Write full, complete sentences — compression creates ambiguity, it does not remove it.
13. Use "must" for an obligation and "may" for a permission. Don't blur the two with "should," "could," or "might."
14. Put a Warning, Caution, or Note in its own labeled block directly before the step it applies to. Don't fold a hazard into a prose sentence where it can be skimmed past.

Workflow

When this skill is active, apply these steps to any text Claude writes or rewrites:

1. **Tag the content.** Mark each sentence as procedural (an instruction) or descriptive (an explanation).
2. **Rewrite for voice and tense.** Convert to active voice. Convert every verb to simple present or simple past.

3. **Split.** Break any sentence with more than one instruction, or over the word limit, into separate numbered steps.
4. **Vocabulary pass.** Replace synonyms with one consistent term per concept. Flag any word likely outside the ~900-word core list and either replace it or declare it as a technical term in a short glossary at the top of the document.
5. **Add safety blocks.** Insert Warning/Caution/Note blocks ahead of any step involving a hazard or an irreversible action.
6. **Self-check** against the checklist below before returning the output.

Self-check checklist

- [ ] Every instruction sentence is 20 words or fewer
- [ ] Every descriptive sentence is 25 words or fewer
- [ ] One instruction per sentence, no "and"/"or" chaining separate actions
- [ ] Active voice throughout, imperative mood for instructions
- [ ] No present perfect, past perfect, future perfect, or progressive tense
- [ ] The same concept always uses the same word
- [ ] No noun string longer than three words
- [ ] No dropped subjects, articles, or relative pronouns
- [ ] Sequential actions are a numbered list, not a paragraph
- [ ] Hazards and irreversible steps have their own Warning/Caution/ Note block

Example

Before (standard English): "Once the diagnostic has been completed and the results have been reviewed by the technician, the panel can be reinstalled, assuming no further anomalies were detected."

After (STE):

1. Do the diagnostic test.
2. Look at the results.
3. If there are no more problems, install the panel again.

Scope note

This skill applies the publicly documented principles of ASD-STE100 Issue 9 (January 2025 — 53 writing rules, ~900-word dictionary, published by ASD). It does not reproduce ASD's copyrighted dictionary or rule text verbatim. For certification-grade compliance work (for example, aircraft maintenance manuals under a formal STE audit), get the official specification and word list at asd-ste100.org.